

EDM 101 – Ethics and Patients' Rights in Dental Medicine

Lecture 10

Ethical Considerations in Pediatric Dentistry

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This classes learning outcomes

By the end of this lecture you are able to

- Understand ethical challenges in treating children.
- Explain informed consent in pediatric dentistry.
- Balance autonomy, beneficence, and parental influence.
- Analyze ethical dilemmas in pediatric cases.



Why do we consider Pediatric Dentistry to be different

- A. Children are still developing
- B. Limited ability to decide
- C. They depend on their parents
- D. There are emotional and psychological factors



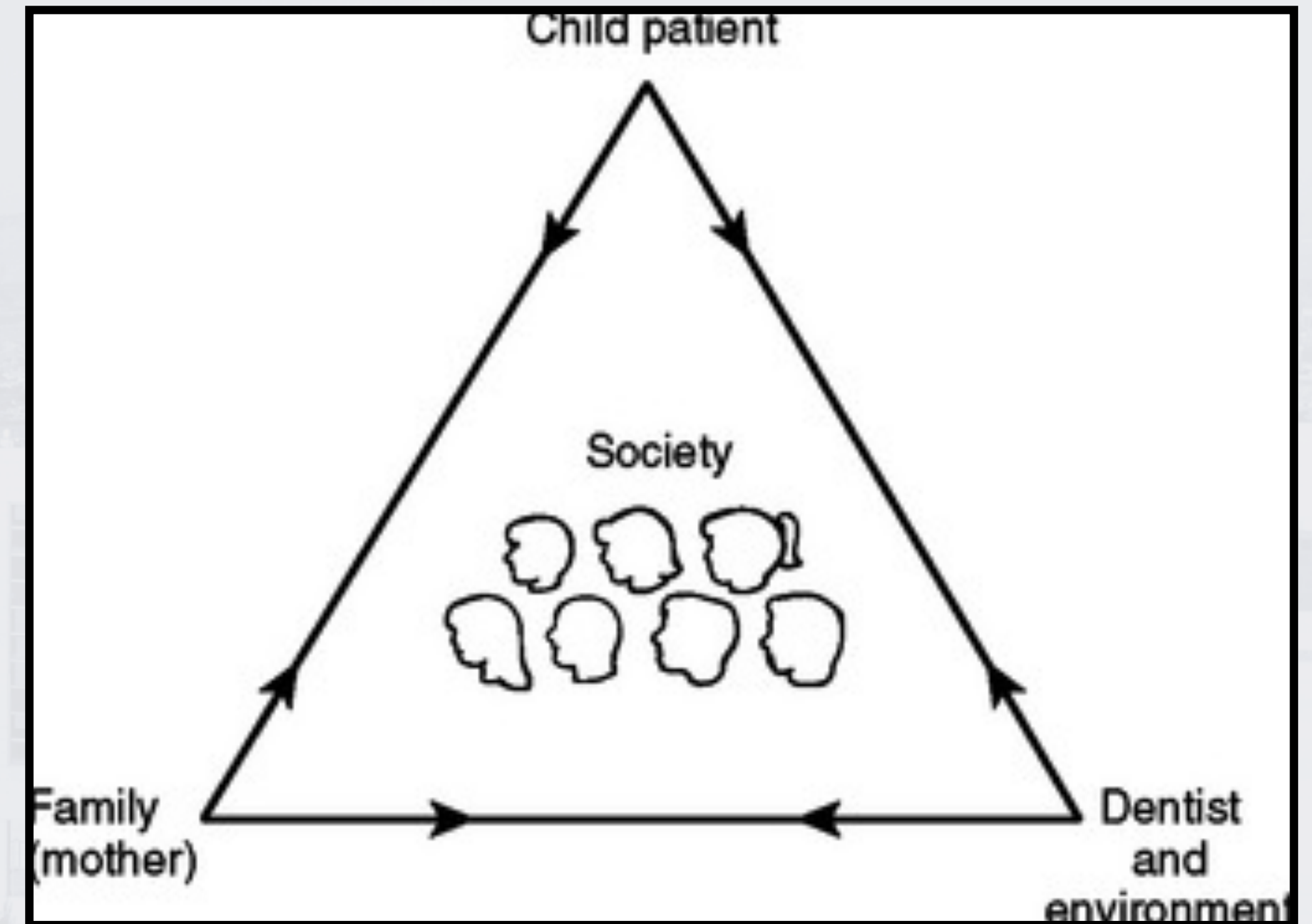
- If treatment is essential, parents and dentists prioritize the child's benefit.
- A child's autonomy is different from an adult's, so communication is important.
- The dentist should explain treatment in a simple, age-appropriate way to involve the child and make them feel safe.



Triangle in Pediatric Dentistry

Three entities are involved:

1. Dentist
2. Parent
3. Child



Decisions are not made by one person; they involve all three.



Ethical Principles

- Autonomy
- Beneficence
- Non-maleficence
- Justice



Communication with Children

- A. You must use simple language
- B. You must consider age and development
- C. You must make the child feel safe



Informed Consent in Children

- The parents will give legal consent for the child
- The child should still be involved



Child Assent

Meaning:

- A. The child should agree to the treatment
- B. Even if not legally required



Balancing Autonomy and Beneficence

The problem might be:

- A. Child refuses treatment
- B. But treatment is needed

This might create a conflict between respecting autonomy and doing what is best for the child.



Integrity (Dignity)

- Respecting the child as a person
- Not ignoring the child's feelings
- Not focusing only on the parents



Autonomy in Children

- A. Not fully developed autonomy
- B. Their autonomy grows with age
- C. Their autonomy must be respected gradually



Role of the parents

Parents:

- Should give consent
- Should act in the child's best interest

BUT:

- They may have conflicts due to (fear, time, stress)



Dentist as Child Advocate

A dentist must:

- A. Protect the child's best interest
- B. Question harmful decisions
- C. Balance parent and child needs

A dentist's duty is to the child first.



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When Principles Conflict

Such as:

- Child refuses treatment
- Treatment is beneficial

The conflict:

- Autonomy vs Beneficence



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When to Postpone Treatment

- A. If it's not urgent
- B. If the child is very anxious
- C. If better cooperation will be achieved later



When Immediate Treatment is Needed

The dentist should act immediately when

- A. Trauma(avulsion) happens
- B. Infection is present

In emergencies, beneficence may override autonomy



Pain Control & Behavior Management

The dentist must try to:

- A. Reduce pain
- B. Use behavior techniques
- C. Consider sedation if needed

Reduction of suffering is an ethical treatment.



Child Neglect and Abuse

The dentists must have the skills to:

- Recognize signs
- Report appropriately



Ethical Analysis

Consider:

- Child
- Parent
- Dentist
- Society

Evaluate using:

- Autonomy
- Beneficence
- Justice



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Summary:

- Pediatric ethics is complex
- Child, plus parent, plus dentist interaction
- Balancing autonomy and beneficence
- Always act in child's best interest



Thank You!



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